

Australia Daily Brief

Wednesday, September 23, 2026

1,944 words · 8 min read

RE: Fiji constitution review targets coup immunity · US embassy warns Canberra on social media law · AFR tips double RBA rate rise · PNG frees thirty-nine trafficking victims · Nauru reclaims name Naoero at UN

ASX 200

8,765

+0.79%

AUD/USD

0.7083

-0.07%

NZX 50

13,822

+1.46%

NZD/USD

0.5700

-0.35%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Fiji's Constitution Review Commission recommends repealing coup-era immunity covering the 1987, 2000, and 2006 coups, a change that would touch Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka, who led the 1987 coup; Rabuka says the Supreme Court's ruling on immunity must stand and confirms the February 6, 2027 election deadline is unchanged.
- 2 The U.S. embassy in Canberra formally warned that Australia's draft social media algorithm law risks facilitating censorship, a rare direct rebuke that lands as Anthropic and OpenAI separately press Canberra to loosen its AI training ban.
- 3 The Australian Financial Review reports the RBA is expected to raise the cash rate on September 29, 2026 and again in November, reversing the two consecutive holds at 4.35 percent recorded through August.

• TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji review recommends scrapping coup immunity, bicameral parliament

Fiji's Constitution Review Commission has recommended repealing the "absolute and irrevocable immunity" shielding participants in the 1987, 2000 and 2006 coups from prosecution, a change that would touch Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka**, who led the 1987 coup. The *236-page report*, tabled at a special sitting in Suva on Tuesday, also proposes restoring a bicameral parliament of sixty seats, constitutional recognition for the Great Council of Chiefs, and refocusing the military on external defence. Cabinet says tabling does not equal adoption.

per ABC News: "Fiji proposes scrapping immunity for past coup leaders including current PM" · also RNZ Pacific (wire)

US-AUSTRALIA

US embassy warns Australia's algorithm law risks censorship

The U.S. embassy in Canberra issued a formal response warning that Australia's draft law letting users opt out of systems that choose what appears in their feeds could amount to censorship of legitimate speech, an unusual direct intervention in Australian domestic regulation. The warning lands as **Anthony Albanese** presses a "digital duty of care" framework at the UN General Assembly, and as **Donald Trump** rejected what he called a "globalist scheme" to regulate AI from the same podium.

per NYT Asia Pacific: "U.S. Rebukes Australia Over Proposed Limits on Social Media Algorithms" · also Reuters · also Bloomberg

TRADE-ECONOMY

AFR: RBA on track for two rate rises before Christmas

The Reserve Bank is expected to raise the cash rate on September 29, 2026 and again in November, the Australian Financial Review reports, reversing the *two consecutive holds* at 4.35 percent recorded through August. Restoring inflation to target should now be the bank's priority, the paper argues, even at the cost of higher unemployment. Shadow Treasurer **Tim Wilson** and Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** have opened a parallel fight over income tax cuts and productivity.

per AFR: "RBA interest rates: Inflation fight to drive up unemployment"

• OVERNIGHT

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Anthropic, OpenAI push Australia to loosen AI training ban](#) · Reuters

Anthropic and OpenAI have called on Canberra to relax its ban on using copyrighted material to train AI models, adding industry pressure to a fast-moving dispute over Australian digital regulation. The push runs alongside Washington's separate warning that the algorithm opt-out proposal risks censorship, putting two American fronts against the same legislative package.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[One year after recognition, little has changed for Palestinians](#) · ABC Politics

A year after Australia joined France, Canada and the U.K. in recognising Palestinian statehood, Palestinian Authority deputy foreign minister **Omar Awadallah** says settler violence in the West Bank has soared and conditions in Gaza continue to kill daily. The anniversary raises the question of what diplomatic recognition has delivered on the ground.

AU-POLITICS

[Hockey says fiscal reform needs a 'financial crisis' to happen](#) · ABC News

Former treasurer **Joe Hockey** says voters will not back meaningful budget reform without a crisis, pointing to the backlash that forced the Abbott government to abandon most of its first-budget cuts. Federal debt has passed *\$1 trillion*, and rising global interest rates have thrown out forecasts for the fastest-growing line in the federal budget.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Former ASD chief backs Albanese's push for AI guardrails](#) · ABC Politics

Rachel Noble, former Director-General of the Australian Signals Directorate, has backed Canberra's campaign for tighter international AI safeguards, hours after Trump rejected the push at the General

Assembly. Anthropic chief executive **Dario Amodei** and OpenAI chief executive **Sam Altman** were due to brief the UN Security Council the same day.

• STAT OF THE DAY

31 million acres

Ocean floor in proposed US deep-sea mining lease

American Samoa's governor wants the lease confined to scientific and environmental research rather than commercial extraction.

ABC Pacific

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

ADM podcast examines AUKUS pressure points and DroneShield

Australian Defence Magazine's episode 182 takes up what it terms AUKUS pressure points alongside developments at counter-drone firm DroneShield. The discussion follows this week's first test-firing of a US and Australian-developed heavyweight torpedo from the British uncrewed undersea vessel XV Excalibur, carried in yesterday's brief.

• PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

PNG police rescue thirty-nine Indonesians from trafficking ring

Papua New Guinea police executed search warrants at a downtown Port Moresby residence on Tuesday and freed five women and thirty-four men from Indonesia allegedly held against their will and forced to run online scams, detaining four Chinese nationals. Police Commissioner **David Manning** said there would be "no leniency for those who traffic and exploit people."

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu teachers resume strike over unmet pay claims

The Vanuatu Teachers Union began industrial action on September 21, with secretary general **Jonathan Yona** saying the Teaching Service Commission failed to deliver items agreed in a signed Memorandum of Conciliation. The Commission says it has received no official strike notice, that financial obligations have been met, and has told teachers to keep reporting to schools.

NAURU · STUFF

Nauru tells UN to use its original name, Naoero

Nauru's president told the UN General Assembly the country has altered its name and reclaimed its heritage as Naoero, urging delegates to "say our name." The move follows Kiribati's own debate over reviving its ancestral name, Tungaru, reported in this brief on September 22.

FIJI · FBC NEWS (FIJI)

Fiji says climate relocation remains a last resort under Ocean of Peace treaty

Fiji's Ministry of Environment and Climate Change told the Standing Committee on Foreign Affairs and Defence that relocation will only be considered when communities can no longer safely remain where they are, in submissions on the Fiji-Australia and Ocean of Peace Treaty. Permanent Secretary **Sivendra Michael** said adaptation is the ministry's priority.

REGIONAL · ABC PACIFIC

American Samoa governor opposes commercial deep-sea mining lease

Governor **Pulaali'i Nikolao Pula** says a proposed U.S. deep-sea mining lease covering more than *31 million acres* of ocean floor should be confined to scientific and environmental research. American Samoan academic **Elora Raymond** said the instrument is a commercial lease that could open decades of mining off the territory's coast. The decision rests with Washington.

VANUATU · ABC PACIFIC

Vanuatu NGOs demand maritime safety reform after MV Matui deaths

The Vanuatu Association of Non-Governmental Organisations is pressing the government for maritime reform following the MV Matui disaster, seeking more frequent vessel and safety-equipment inspections and more resources for maritime authorities. "The safety is a priority for everyone," VANGO representative **Max Zacharie** said. Inter-island ferries are a principal means of travel between Vanuatu's islands.

REGIONAL · RNZ NATIONAL

Pacific journalists investigating drug trafficking face rising threats

The president of the Pacific Islands News Association told the eighth Pacific Media Summit that reporters covering drug trafficking face increasing threats to their personal safety, calling for stronger protections. The summit opened in Savusavu, Fiji, on September 22.

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

Rabuka confirms February 6, 2027 election deadline unchanged

Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka has confirmed the February 6, 2027 deadline for Fiji's general election stands, as the government signals a new constitution could be in place by Christmas Eve. Opposition MP **Rinesh Sharma** has warned against rushing the process: "The process should not be rushed."

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Samoa Airways to resume Upolu-Savai'i flights from October 8

Samoa Airways will restore scheduled flights between Fagali'i and Maota three days a week from October 8, nearly ten months after the last service on December 10, 2025. Chief executive **Fauoo Fatu Tielu** said fares will be \$200 *one-way*, with the board approving the route on September 15 after resolving airport readiness, pilot and aircraft constraints.

● NEW ZEALAND

NZ HERALD

Peters calls the state of the world 'monstrous', argues realism over idealism

Foreign Minister **Winston Peters** describes the current international environment as "monstrous" and makes the case for realism over idealism in New Zealand's foreign policy, in an interview published as the November 7 general election approaches.

WASHINGTON POST

Gloriavale funding trust stripped of charity status over child labour

The funding trust behind a New Zealand commune has lost its charitable status over child labour and other misconduct, the Washington Post reports, in a decision with implications for regulatory oversight of New Zealand charities.

RNZ

Survey finds 66 percent of New Zealanders think they can spot an AI fake

Avast's 2026 Safe Tech Report found 66 *percent* of New Zealand adults believe they would recognise an AI-generated fake, while 40 percent admitted sharing or considering sharing sensitive information with an AI tool, including CVs and work documents at 21 percent each. The report calls the gap an "AI confidence trap".

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Taylor claims \$83 billion budget black hole as Chalmers dangles tax cuts

Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor** has put a *\$83 billion* figure on what he calls Labor's budget black hole, while Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** floats income tax cuts. The exchange opens a fresh productivity and tax fight as the Reserve Bank flags further rate rises and job losses to tame inflation.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Coalition unveils eight-point plan to unwind Labor's energy agenda

The Coalition has released an eight-point plan to end what it calls Labor's green revolution, launched at The Australian's Energy Nation Forum. The forum is also canvassing whether Australia's grid can power a data centre build-out the paper values at *\$200 billion*.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Joyce calls Liberal MP a 'clown' over confidence and supply denials

One Nation MP **Barnaby Joyce** has attacked a Liberal MP over denials that the parties are discussing a confidence and supply arrangement, after Joyce said he had held talks with senior Liberals about a minority government scenario. Liberal MPs deny any negotiation is under way.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Bullock issues 'call to action' on the Intergenerational Report, warns on AI bubble

RBA governor **Michele Bullock** has framed the Intergenerational Report as a call to action for government and warned of an asset bubble in artificial intelligence. Her remarks follow the report's projection, carried in this brief on September 21, that deaths will outnumber births by the 2060s.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · AU DEFENCE

Australian defence ministerial doorstep in Fiji

The Australian defence ministry has published the transcript of a doorstep held in Fiji and dated September 23, 2026. It follows last week's Nadi defence cooperation meeting and Fiji's parliamentary consideration of the Fiji-Australia and Ocean of Peace Treaty.

JOINT STATEMENT · AU MINISTERIAL

Wong joins 12th ministerial meeting of Friends of the CTBT

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** has issued a release on the twelfth ministerial meeting of the Friends of the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty, a grouping Australia co-convenes. The treaty carries particular weight

for Pacific members given the region's nuclear testing history.

COMMUNIQUE · PIF COMMUNIQUES

Pacific leaders take digital priorities to UNGA81

Pacific leaders are carrying a digital agenda into the 81st session of the UN General Assembly, according to Forum material reported by the Samoa Observer. The push runs parallel to Australia's campaign for international AI guardrails, which Washington has rejected.

• UPCOMING

OCT
8

Samoa Airways resumes Upolu-Savai'i flights

Restores domestic air links severed since December 2025 for Samoa's second-largest island.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Advance voting opens October 26; the result determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues.

DEC
2026

Possible Fiji constitutional referendum

Government has signalled a new constitution could be in place by Christmas Eve, on the eve of an election campaign.

FEB
6

Deadline for Fiji's general election

Rabuka confirms the date is unchanged despite the constitutional review timetable.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Navigating the tides: how fiscal discipline sustains social protection in Kiribati

Kiribati's Minister for Women, Youth, Sport and Social Affairs **Ruth Cross Kwansing** sets out how the atoll state funds pensions, disability support and unemployment relief from ocean revenue. She also serves as the Pacific Islands Forum Political Champion for Gender Equality and Social Inclusion.

PNG POST-COURIER

PNG National Research Institute maps strategies on internal displacement

A new edition of the National Research Institute's Spotlight examines internal displacement in Papua New Guinea and sets out strategies to reduce its impact.

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY

LOWY INTERPRETER

Beyond the Quad: India-New Zealand relations find purpose

Trade and maritime cooperation are filling in a relationship that people-to-people ties alone could not sustain, the Interpreter argues. The India-New Zealand free trade pact takes effect October 20.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

The UN funding crisis: implications for the Pacific

Saber Salem notes the General Assembly approved a \$3.45 billion regular budget for 2026, about 7 percent below 2025, while outstanding assessments stood at roughly \$2.8 billion in April 2026 against \$2.4 billion a year earlier. Cash conservation measures constrain delivery of climate and development programmes in small island states.

PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

From Palau to New York: a Pacific perspective on meaningful participation

Chia-ping Liu writes that Taiwan's Foreign Minister **Lin Chia-lung** led its delegation to the 55th Pacific Islands Forum leaders meeting in Palau from August 31 to September 4, 2026, and notes Guam Governor **Lourdes Leon Guerrero** called for Guam to move from associate to full Forum membership.

PNG POST-COURIER

Australia works with PNG on safe AI adoption

Australia is working with Papua New Guinea and other Indo-Pacific partners on safe, secure and inclusive adoption of artificial intelligence, involving PNG's Department of Information and Communications Technology secretary **Steven Matainaho**.

● ANALYSIS AND OPINION

LOWY INSTITUTE

Can the middle hold? Australian middle power diplomacy in a ruptured world order

A Lowy Institute publication examining the durability of Australia's middle power diplomacy as the rules-based order fragments.

Argument: Australian middle power diplomacy faces a test in a ruptured international order.

THE DIPLOMAT

The Transitions Shaping Australia's Future

A reading of the latest Intergenerational Report and the demographic, technological and fiscal shifts it projects.

Argument: The Treasury's Intergenerational Report identifies five transitions that will define Australia's coming decades.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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